



▲ DAZZLING WHITE TRUBI MARL OF THE TURKISH STEPS

The Amalfi Coast

Location Sorrento Peninsula, west coast of Italy

The southern coastline of the Sorrento Peninsula is one of the most beautiful in the world. Mountains of limestone and volcanic deposits plunge into the sea in a stunning scene of precipitous crags, with narrow valleys descending steeply through them to the shore. The seismic activity associated with Vesuvius, an active volcano not far to the north, produces frequent earthquakes, and the rocks of the peninsula are extensively faulted. The Amalfi Coast experiences more flash floods and landslides than any other region of Italy.

The Turkish Steps

Location Southern Sicily, Italy

These cliffs of slightly inclined strata of white Trubi marl have been eroded into a series of long, parallel steps. Trubi marl is a relatively soft calcareous sedimentary rock, which was deposited on the ocean floor

about 5 million years ago. It contains the tracks of animals, probably worms that lived within it while it was being deposited.

Other coasts, islands, and reefs in Europe

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Africa

Legzira

Location Atlantic coast of southern Morocco

Until 2016, there were two massive arches of red sandstone on the beach at Legzira. The layers of sandstone are 100–150 million

years old and were deposited on an unconformity over much older granite. They derive their coloration from iron oxide in the natural cement binding the grains in the rock. The arches were eroded by the action of waves, with one of them collapsing onto the beach in September 2016.

Banc d'Arguin

Location Golfe d'Arguin, west coast of Mauritania

A national park covers 4,630 square miles (12,000 square km) of this coastline—which includes sand dunes, seagrass flats, intertidal mud, sand, and shell fragments—as well as the shallow Golfe d'Arguin stretching up to 40 miles (60 km) from the shore. An offshore upwelling zone generates huge quantities of invertebrate food for fish and birds, with up to 50,000 pairs of colonial birds breeding and more than two million wintering in the park.

Socotra

Location Arabian Sea

One of Earth's most isolated islands, which originated as part of a continent rather than as new oceanic crust, Socotra is 150 miles (240 km) from the African mainland. It is also a major center of endemic plants and animals. Socotra has an area of 1,415 square miles (3,665 square km), divided between coastal plains, a limestone plateau with caves and other karst features, and a mountainous core. The climate is arid or semiarid, apart from high elevations, which experience more rainfall. Once part of the supercontinent of Gondwanaland, it became separated when the Gulf of Aden opened up. More than one-third of its plants are found nowhere else, including the bizarre-looking dragon's blood tree, and there are also endemic birds, reptiles, and invertebrates.

Coffee Bay

Location Eastern Cape province, South Africa

Near this coastal settlement is the spectacular Hole in the Rock formation, where wave action has punched a hole through an offshore cliff of shale and sandstone. Erosion has created a rock arch, rather than dividing the cliff into two stacks, because a thick intrusion of hard volcanic dolerite lies above the less resistant shale and sandstone, which is 260 million years old. The arch is large enough for a yacht to sail through at high tide.

► **DRAGON'S BLOOD TREES AT SOCOTRA**

